

RED FLAGS — IMAGE/REFER

- Saddle anaesthesia, bladder/bowel involvement, progressive weakness
- Fever with spinal tenderness; significant trauma; age >65 with new pain + weight loss

FIRST-LINE MANAGEMENT

- Stay active; avoid bed rest beyond 48 h
- Paracetamol 650 mg every 8 h OR Ibuprofen 400 mg every 8 h after food (short course)
- Muscle spasm: consider short course only per local formulary

REVIEW

- Reassess at 2 weeks; persistent >6 weeks = imaging pathway